

to support employees and even their families. Added to that is a flexible benefits initiative. “This gives employees the security they need to choose benefits that matter to them at their stage of life. It relates to insurance, lifestyle and development,” explains Mukerji.

Perhaps the most interesting aspect of the company is its India wellness strategy, which she explains is, “a structured, uniform and holistic employee experience catering to the most prevalent facets of wellness over and above the existing benefits”. Within the strategy is the India Wellness Program that helps employees and their families achieve physical, emotional, financial and social wellness. Ambati Venu, Vice President of Pharmaceuticals at Abbott India, explains that sustainability for the company means delivering long-term impact for the people it serves. “It is about shaping the future of healthcare and helping the greatest number of people live better and healthier lives. For this, we constantly work to build a strong, more sustainable Abbott and that is why our 2030 sustainability plan includes targeted actions to create the workforce of tomorrow,” he says.

At Abbott, mental health well-being is covered through the Mind Strong initiative, also as a part of the India wellness strategy. “The objective has been to increase awareness on the issue, apart from providing a preventive mechanism to manage stress, sleep and other issues related to anxiety,” says Mukerji, adding that it is an integrated solution aimed at creating a culture of acceptance on mental and emotional well-being.

In a world where talent is the scarcest good, companies like Abbott spend a substantial amount of



KEY HR INITIATIVES

► **Customised counselling to support employees and families**

► **Wide range of benefits for employees at**

any stage of life

► **Focus on facets of wellness over and above the existing benefits**

► **Policies for work-life balance**

► **People can support communities where the company operates**

time, money and effort in upskilling employees. That includes developing new skill sets and digital skills across levels, and expertise in using AI-based tools and bots. “We have a well-defined development process aligned with our talent strategy. Employees are offered many development opportunities and have access to appropriate training,” she explains. Some of the initiatives include learning gigs on the company’s career connect portal called SmaHRty—an AI-enabled HR chatbot that helps transform employee experience and offers real-time resolutions to queries on HR policies and benefits.

In line with what is taking place across the world, diversity, equity and inclusion are key at Abbott India. A highlight of this is the Women Leaders of Abbott (WLA) platform aimed at attracting, retaining and advancing women talent in the organisation. Mukerji says that WLA’s agenda has three strategic

pillars—content, inspire and grow—and this covers areas such as creating an engaging culture, having a meaningful and enabling work environment for women employees and improving the gender diversity ratio. Other initiatives under the WLA platform include Wo-Mentoring, Empower, Happy Feet and Working Mothers of Abbott.

Abbott, as a part of its 2030 sustainability plan, is also looking to address the shortage of global STEM (science, technology, engineering and mathematics) talent. This will be done through Abbott’s STEM programming and internships at high schools and colleges. The plan is to create opportunities for over 100,000 young people, with half of them coming from under-represented groups. For Abbott India, life clearly goes beyond work. **BT**

@krishnagopalan